

STRATEGY BRIEF

DataHooks

Repositioning for the AI Era

Prepared for internal alignment

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The Threat

AI coding agents like Claude Code, Cursor, and Cwork can now perform many of the tasks that data agencies have traditionally sold: writing ETL scripts, building dbt models, setting up Fivetran connectors, normalizing schemas, and configuring warehouses.

Tools like DeathByClawd.com have gone viral by scoring SaaS companies and service businesses on their replaceability by AI. The thesis is simple: if your offering is a workflow that can be described in a markdown file, it can be automated away.

For a data agency that positions itself as *“we clean, unify, and migrate your data,”* the score would not be flattering. That positioning describes a task list, not a defensible business.

What AI Can Replace

- Writing deduplication scripts and data cleaning logic
- Building and configuring ETL/ELT pipelines
- Setting up dbt models and transformation layers
- Configuring warehouse schemas (Snowflake, BigQuery, Redshift)
- Creating standard dashboards and reports
- Writing email nurture sequences and sales automation logic

What AI Cannot Replace

- Sitting between sales, marketing, engineering, and ops to negotiate what a “lead” actually means
- Facilitating cross-functional alignment on shared data definitions
- Making judgment calls about which data problems matter and which are noise
- Building trust with a client to the point where they hand over production database credentials
- Being accountable when something breaks — carrying SLAs, E&O; insurance, incident response
- Understanding the business context that determines whether a dashboard is useful or misleading

The gap is clear: implementation is becoming commoditized, but strategy, alignment, and accountability are not. DataHooks needs to reposition around the things AI makes harder, not easier, to replace.

The Repositioning

From: Data Implementation Agency

“We clean your CRM, build your pipelines, set up your warehouse, and hand you the keys.”

To: Data Agency

“Your data is a mess. We figure out why, align your teams on what needs to happen, and make it work. How we execute is our problem, not yours.”

Old Positioning (Vulnerable)	New Positioning (Defensible)
We clean your data	We figure out what’s actually wrong
We build pipelines	We align your teams on data definitions
We set up your warehouse	We make your dashboards trustworthy
We hand you the keys	We keep it running and evolving
Project-based, one-time	Land with project, expand to retainer
Sells labor hours	Sells outcomes and accountability

The Core Insight

Every mid-size company has data problems, but the problems are rarely technical at their root. The data is messy because nobody agreed on what it should look like. The dashboards are wrong because different teams defined the same metric differently. The automations fire at the wrong time because the underlying data model was built by one team without consulting the others.

DataHooks sits in the gap between teams. We have the cross-functional fluency to understand what sales needs, what marketing is measuring, what engineering built, and what ops is actually doing — and we translate between all of them to create a data layer that everyone trusts.

Then we make it happen. Fast. The implementation layer is accelerated because the industry has better tools than ever. But the strategic layer — the alignment, the definitions, the prioritization — that's where the value lives.

What DataHooks Actually Does

Phase 1: Understand the Business

Before we touch any data, we talk to the people who use it. We interview stakeholders across sales, marketing, product, engineering, and ops. We map out what each team thinks the data says, what they wish it said, and where the disagreements are.

- Stakeholder interviews across all data-dependent teams
- Data audit: what exists, where it lives, who owns it, what's broken
- Gap analysis: what the business needs vs. what the data currently supports
- Alignment doc: shared definitions, agreed priorities, and a clear plan

Phase 2: Fix the Foundation

With alignment in hand, we do the work. Clean the CRM. Normalize the schemas. Build the pipelines. Set up the dashboards that people actually need. Create the automations that should have been running months ago.

- Data cleaning: deduplication, validation, normalization
- Pipeline buildout: connecting sources, transforming data, ensuring freshness
- Dashboarding: reports that answer real business questions, not vanity metrics
- Automation: email sequences, lead scoring, alerts — things that run on clean data

Phase 3: Prepare for AI

Clean, unified, well-defined data is the prerequisite for every AI initiative. We prepare your data so that when you're ready to build AI tools, internal copilots, or automated workflows, the foundation is solid.

- Data quality monitoring: automated checks that catch drift before it causes problems
- AI-readiness assessment: which datasets are ready for ML/AI and which need work
- Documentation: what each field means, where it comes from, how it's calculated
- Ongoing support: retainer-based partnership to keep it all running

Revenue Model

Land: Project-Based SOW

Initial engagements are scoped as fixed-price or T&M; projects. Typical entry points include a data audit, CRM cleanup, or dashboard rebuild. These are tangible, completable deliverables that demonstrate value quickly.

Typical project value: \$15K–\$75K depending on scope and complexity.

Expand: Monthly Retainer

After the initial project, clients transition to a monthly retainer for ongoing data operations. This includes monitoring, maintenance, new dashboard builds, automation updates, and strategic advisory as the business evolves.

Typical retainer value: \$5K–\$20K/month depending on stack complexity and support level.

Why This Is Sticky

- We hold the context: we know why each data decision was made and what the tradeoffs were
- Switching cost is organizational, not technical — a new vendor has to re-learn the politics
- Ongoing value: data stacks don't stay clean on their own; new tools get added, teams change, schemas drift

- Trust: we have credentials, access, and institutional knowledge that takes months to rebuild

Go-to-Market

Lead Channel: Intrepid Digital

Intrepid Digital is a digital marketing agency that regularly encounters clients with messy data. Their clients need clean analytics, working attribution, and reliable CRM data to run effective campaigns. Intrepid refers these clients to DataHooks for the data layer work.

This is a natural partnership: Intrepid needs the data to be right for their work to perform. DataHooks needs clients who understand they have a data problem. The referral is warm and context-rich.

Secondary Channels

- Content marketing: blog posts demonstrating expertise in cross-functional data problems
- Case studies: anonymized before/after stories showing business impact
- Direct outreach: targeting VP/Director of Ops, RevOps, and Marketing Ops at 50–500 person companies
- Word of mouth: the primary growth engine once initial clients see results

Ideal Client Profile

- 50–500 employees, post-Series A or profitable
- Multiple SaaS tools generating data (CRM, analytics, ad platforms, billing)
- No dedicated data team, or a data team that's underwater
- Actively investing in AI/automation but hitting data quality walls
- Experiencing cross-team friction around metrics, reporting, or data ownership

Why This Survives AI

The DeathByClawd thesis is that businesses built on workflows get replaced by AI agents. The businesses that survive have one or more of three properties:

1. Atoms

Physical infrastructure that can't be forked. DataHooks doesn't have this — and doesn't need it.

2. Regulatory Capture

Compliance requirements that create barriers. DataHooks touches this through GDPR, CCPA, and SOC 2 knowledge, but it's not the primary moat.

3. Trust and Accountability

This is where DataHooks lives. Companies hand us production credentials. We sit in rooms with their leadership team. We're accountable when something breaks. We carry the organizational context that took months to build.

An AI agent can write a pipeline. It cannot negotiate between your VP of Sales and your Head of Engineering about why the pipeline numbers don't match the CRM. It cannot sit in a quarterly business review and explain why the data says what it says. It cannot be the person who gets called at 9pm the night before a board meeting when the numbers look wrong.

DataHooks survives AI because the hard part of data work was never the code. It was always the people.

Website Messaging Direction

The website should be reworked to reflect this positioning. Key principles:

Lead with Outcomes, Not Methods

- Don't say "we clean your CRM" — say "your team stops arguing about which numbers are right"
- Don't say "we build pipelines" — say "your dashboards finally tell the truth"
- Don't say "we set up your warehouse" — say "your AI initiatives have a foundation they can trust"

Never Reveal the Kitchen

- Don't mention AI, Claude, or automation as part of how we work
- Don't name specific tools (Fivetran, dbt, Snowflake) unless a client asks
- The client is buying a result, not a tech stack

Emphasize the Human Layer

- Cross-functional expertise: we speak sales, marketing, engineering, and ops
- Alignment facilitation: we get teams on the same page before building anything
- Accountability: we're on the hook for results, not just deliverables

Hero Copy Direction

Proposed headline: *"Your data works. Your data doesn't."*

Proposed subhead: *"The tools are set up. The integrations are running. But nobody trusts the dashboards, the automations fire wrong, and every team has a different version of the truth. We fix that."*

End of Strategy Brief